

RUN AND HIDE
by Pankaj Mishra
JUGGERNAUT
₹599; 336 pages

Pankaj Mishra used to be sort of famous, in certain circles, for being the editor who 'discovered' Arundhati Roy, getting her manuscript for *The God of Small Things* into the hands of an agent in London. Mishra himself had published a slight travelogue before his brief stint as an editor at HarperCollins India and would go on to publish a slight novel, about the sentimental education of a provincial and bookish young North Indian man in the Himachali hills.

The Romantics, Mishra's debut novel, was an extension to a sparkling essay he published around the same time in *The New York Review of Books* (NYRB) about long, aimless days spent reading the formidable American critic Edmund Wilson and browsing the dusty stacks of the Banaras Hindu University library. Mishra's association with the *NYRB*—the product of a convivial dinner in Delhi with its editor, Barbara Epstein—led to 'Edmund Wilson in Benares' and turned him on to reportage, and the long, searching intellectual inquiries for which, disappointingly, there has rarely, if ever, been space in Indian journals.

Since then, Mishra has ascended to the top rung of global writers, his books and reviews provoking angry, distinctly unaugust language in otherwise staid, august pages. The likes of Niall Ferguson and Jordan Peterson—academics who appeal to those nostalgic for empire and patriarchy (as if these are no longer dominant forces, albeit in a different guise)—have been reduced to spittle-flecked tirades and issuing empty threats of legal and even physical reprisal. Others have made much of Mishra's social ascent, through marriage, to the heart of the British establishment, as if this somehow undermined him as a voice from the 'global South'.

Now, rather like Roy, two decades on from his first novel, Mishra has swapped the sound and fury, the bitter polemics of non-fiction and political engagement for the ostensibly calmer shores of literary fiction. His second novel, *Run and Hide,* is now out and, as with Roy, it is an expression of the themes that have run through all his work, whether memoir, essay, intellectual history, op-ed, or novel. For Mishra, the impulse that animates his writing is his desire to at once be wholly a part of this world and its noise and to retreat, monk-like, into silence and meditation in the mountains.

MISHRA SAYS RETURNING TO THE NOVEL HAS ALLOWED HIM TO "EXPLORE THE FULL EMOTIONAL POTENTIAL" OF A "WHOLE STOREHOUSE OF MEMORIES, OF GROWING UP IN RAILWAY TOWNS, FOR INSTANCE..."

Speaking down a Zoom line from London, Mishra acknowledges that fiction does enable him to "abandon the generalities of nonfiction" and to delve "more deeply into the particularities, the shapes of individual lives". Returning to the novel has, he says, allowed him to "explore the full emotional potential" of a "whole storehouse of memories, of growing up in railway towns, for instance", an experience of small-town India inaccessible, frankly, to most Indian literary novelists writing in English.

In Walter Benjamin's famous essay, 'The Storyteller' (which Mishra mentions in our conversation), he writes of the "resident tiller of the soil" and the "trading seaman" and how audiences for tales will happily listen to either—he who has ranged far and wide and seen the strange and the new, and he who has stayed at home and "who knows the local tales and traditions". Mishra is both, the man rooted to his spot, rapt by decay, by the mouldering effect of stasis, and the man forever on the move, restless and hungry for experience.

Arun Dwivedi, the narrator in *Run and Hide* (like Samar, the protagonist of *The Romantics*), is a sensitive, provincial man who seeks refuge, solitude and salvation in the mountains. Dwivedi is in retreat from the ravages of his small-town upbring-